Vision
&
Invitation to Contribute



CANOE VALLEY SCHOOL



An early class for the Pleasant Valley school program, held in the early 1990s at Good Shepherd Church.

THE NEED

Decorah has a long history of educational experimentation rooted in community initiative, family leadership, and a desire for learning that serves the whole child. From early homeschooling efforts to the formation of Pleasant Valley School in the early 1990s, to the growth of Home School Assistance Program, Northeast Iowa Montessori, Kinderhaus, and Red Oak Outdoor School, families in this region have repeatedly created alternatives when existing structures did not meet their children's needs.

Families who value holistic, place-based, hands-on, and student-centered learning often find strong choices for early childhood and elementary years, but far fewer pathways for middle and high school students. Canoe Valley School answers this gap. Our school seeks to build on Decorah's longstanding spirit of educational innovation into the secondary years, offering adolescents a rigorous and deeply human school experience rooted in the land, the community, and the emerging purposes of young people themselves.

OUR MISSION

Canoe Valley School aims to support students as they cultivate their whole selves and their connection to place, so they can find their path in life and proceed boldly, with creativity, care, and competency. Students, teachers, parents, and community members pursue this work together through self-directed, relational learning, and as a whole the school community aims to serve the place we live and help create a more beautiful, just, and abundant world.

OUR APPROACH

We are a developing secondary school for students ages 12–18, rooted in the Canoe Creek watershed and the broader Decorah community. Our approach grows from a long local tradition of non-traditional education, while responding to a clear need for meaningful middle and high school options that are hands-on, place-based, rigorous, inclusive, and deeply human.

The pages that follow show how this vision becomes a school where outdoor and farm-based education, project-based learning, and shared governance come together. This campus is designed for learning in relationship with land and community. Together, these elements address the needs families have named for adolescents in the Decorah area: belonging, purpose, academic preparation, real-world skills, connection to nature, and space for young people to discover who they are and what they can contribute.

OUR CURRICULUM

Whole-person learning means educating the full range of a young person's capacities—not only intellect, but also curiosity, creativity, emotional life, relationships, embodied experience, practical skill, and sense of purpose. At Canoe Valley School, this approach comes to life through interdisciplinary, project-based work weaving together seven core subject areas:

Communication Arts: reading, writing, storytelling, rhetoric, deep listening, media production, and foreign languages.

Quantitative and Spatial Reasoning: arithmetic, geometry, algebra, statistics, modeling, spatial thinking, and systems thinking.

Social Sciences and Community Life: history, philosophy, sociology, geography, economics, psychology, civic engagement, and community stewardship.

Scientific Inquiry and Ecological Arts: observation, experimentation, biology, ecology, chemistry, physics, geology, botany, horticulture, regenerative agriculture, and land management.

Practical Life and Wellness: health, nutrition, cooking, repair, hospitality, personal finance, household management, and everyday practical skills.

Fine and Practical Arts: drawing, painting, printmaking, ceramics, movement, music, folk arts, woodworking, and fiber arts.

Appropriate Design and Technology: design thinking, architecture, landscape design, sustainable technologies, carpentry, fabrication, & computer science.

"As a homeschooling parent of children with multiple learning differences—including dyslexia, dysgraphia, dyscalculia, and ADHD—I know how important it is to have an environment that embraces those differences and allows students to learn at their own pace and in ways that build on their strengths. When our children reach high school age, those alternative educational options become much more limited. Canoe Valley School fills this gap. We are excited to see it come to fruition and to have a place where our children can continue learning in an environment that fosters community, confidence, curiosity, and the skills that are meaningful to them."

Natasha, Parent of Prospective Students

"In my 30 years as an educator, I've come to understand how important it is for people to have a genuine experience of the place where they live and learn. Place-based education gives students the opportunity not only to learn about the world, but to experience it directly—to explore, to ask questions, to work alongside other people, and to develop a sense of meaning, purpose, and confidence. As a science educator, I encourage healthy skepticism, but I also know that skepticism can become something very different when people are surrounded by fear, misinformation, and apocalyptic thinking. There is real value in stepping outside, paying attention to the natural world, and sharing an experience that is physically real and immediate with other human beings. Those experiences can help us become more grounded in the world rather than more fearful of it. That is one of the things I find so compelling about Canoe Valley School."

Birgitta, Prospective Teacher



ARRIVING

At Canoe Valley School, learning begins by arriving in a place that asks something of us. Students enter a campus shaped by woods, water, fields, gardens, and community memory. The school is being built for young people who need room to follow curiosity, develop purpose, and belong to something larger than themselves. We invite you into that work.



AT HOME IN THE FOREST

The heart of our 40+ acre campus is an existing building that can be transformed into classrooms, gathering spaces, offices, and project rooms. Renovation will preserve the character of the place while making it safe, accessible, and ready for daily school life. Your support turns a promising structure into a vibrant center for adolescents, teachers, families, and mentors.

Our first phase will renovate the ground floor of this building, providing two classrooms to support our initial cohort of students.



BEYOND THE CLASSROOM

Canoe Valley is not imagined as a school building with a yard attached. The campus itself is part of the curriculum: a network of gardens, trails, gathering areas, farm spaces, and ecological study sites. Students will learn by moving through these places, noticing patterns, solving problems, and caring for the land that teaches them.

As our program grows, we will create a collection of outdoor learning spaces so that learning can be truly integrated into the landscape.

“As a homeschooling parent, I'm excited to have a secondary school option that aligns more closely with our family values than traditional school. I share in Canoe Valley School's vision of creating belonging and learning in community from a variety of teachers, elders, and community members while allowing spaciousness and choice for students to pursue their own interests. Adolescence is an important time of growth and identity formation and I think Canoe Valley can provide the balance of structure and freedom necessary for my kids to create a strong sense of self as they grow into adulthood.”

Jenn, Parent of Prospective Students

"Passion for learning comes most powerfully from desire, and love, or a mission to accomplish something personally meaningful. This has proven true in my own life for sure, as competencies and knowledge grew organically from what I loved and could not live without, or from a task that attended a great need of someone else's. That such a pathway is being acknowledged and built into the fabric of Canoe Valley School through mentorship and creative planning for students' individual interests, as well as community projects with student input, is a very inspiring and well-overdue option for our community."

Heidi, Community Member



AN INTEGRATED EXPERIENCE

At Canoe Valley, the outdoor campus is woven directly into the core curriculum. Gardens, pasture, orchard, woodland, and farm spaces become living settings for our core focus areas like ecological arts, appropriate design, and practical life, and an inspiration for communication, fine and practical arts, and developing a whole-person approach to wellness. Here, students learn through direct participation in the systems that sustain a place.



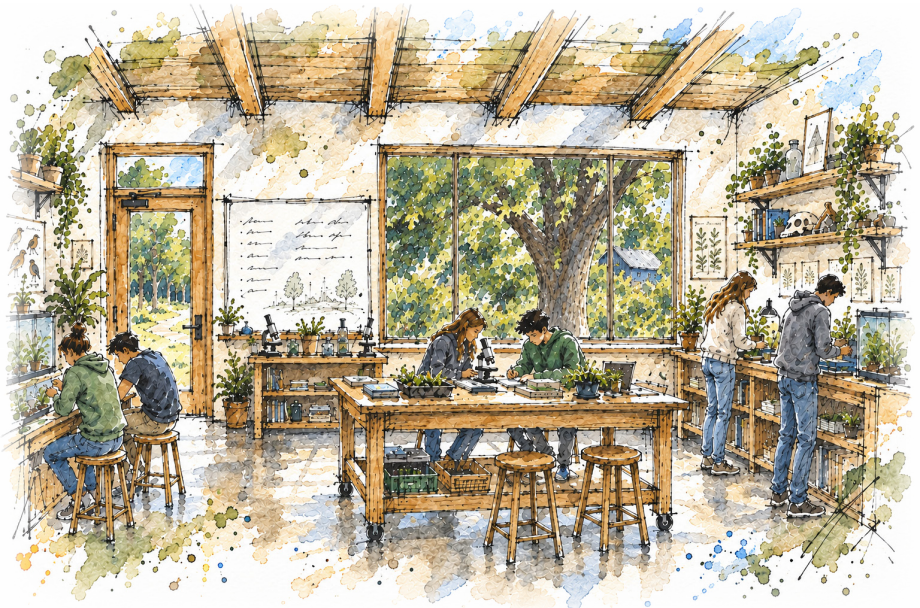
A PLACE TO GATHER

A Canoe Valley class might begin under a roof of leaves or in a simple outdoor pavilion. Students gather with a teacher to listen, ask questions, sketch, write, and notice what the place itself is offering. The point is to deepen academics by giving ideas a setting where they can be felt, tested, and shared.



SELF-DIRECTED LEARNING, TOGETHER

Canoe Valley replaces isolated classes with interdisciplinary projects, but that does not mean abandoning foundations. Students will build skills in reading, writing, scientific inquiry, quantitative reasoning, design, and the arts. They do so through work that asks them to collaborate, revise, make meaning, and connect what they know to the world they inhabit. Learning is documented through multimedia portfolios and written narratives that show growth over time. Instead of reducing a student to a single grade, this creates a richer record of learning and students become authors of their own education.



A SEED FOR GROWTH

Phase 1 of our campus development will focus on renovating the ground floor of the existing building to create two functional classrooms for Canoe Valley's first students.

These spaces will allow the school to launch its initial cohort within the current structure while larger campus improvements continue over time. In addition to the two classrooms, the project will include infrastructure upgrades, restroom modernization, and other necessary improvements to meet modern safety requirements for a school building.



A LEARNING COMMUNITY

Although Canoe Valley is planned as a secondary school, the campus can become a welcoming place for families and community members as well. Gardens, paths, natural play areas, seasonal events, and shared facilities help the school serve more than just the enrolled students. Community members can play active roles in the school's self-directed curriculum by mentoring students in areas of expertise or passion, teaching elective courses, and more. This public-spirited role is part of what makes the project worth supporting. We also imagine the campus landscape as the seed of a broader conversation about land access and commons-based stewardship.



SHARING WHAT WE DO

An important part of Canoe Valley's culture is learning how to share our work outward—with families, neighbors, and the wider community through showcases, events, performances, exhibitions, and gatherings. As renovation progresses, the building will support this outward-facing culture through a flexible community space adjacent to the existing commercial kitchen. This space will allow student work, hospitality, and community life to come together as part of the school's seasonal rhythms. We imagine this space serving as a library, meeting space, dining room, performance space, and gallery.



"Having a place for our young people to grow and explore who they are in the world is a cornerstone for building the world we want to see. Knowing this community is working so hard to bring Canoe Valley School to life gives me so much hope for the future. We are creating a place not just for learning, but for community, growth, connection, and so much more. I cannot wait to see this school and the kids it will support in action!"

Hiliary, Parent of Prospective Students

PHASE 1 FUNDRAISING GOALS

Our Phase 1 goal is to raise $300,000 to prepare Canoe Valley School for its first students. This includes $50,000 to establish the school through organizational development, program planning, early staffing, curriculum work, accreditation preparation, communications, and launch-year readiness. The remaining $250,000 will support renovations and site work, including the ground-floor classrooms, accessibility improvements, basic infrastructure, and other initial improvements toward a campus that can support the school's full vision.

We also welcome gifts directed toward specific elements of the master plan:

- **Community Room:** A flexible gathering space for showcases, performances, meetings, meals, exhibitions, and community events.
- **Gazebo:** A sheltered outdoor classroom and gathering place that supports learning in all seasons.
- **Learning Barn:** A future anchor for farm-based learning, practical work, animal care, storage, and hands-on projects.
- **Play Area:** A natural space for movement, exploration, imagination, and intergenerational community use.
- **Amphitheater:** An outdoor setting for presentations, performances, councils, storytelling, and seasonal gatherings.
- **Gardens and Orchard:** Living classrooms for ecological arts, regenerative growing, food systems, and place-based learning.

Whether supporting the full Phase 1 goal or giving toward a particular campus element, each donation helps bring Canoe Valley School from vision into daily life.

HOW TO SUPPORT US FINANCIALLY

Canoe Valley School is a community-supported project, and financial gifts are essential to bringing the school into being. Donations will support Phase 1 renovations, classroom materials, outdoor learning spaces, accessibility improvements, and the launch of the first student cohort. Your gift helps create a place where adolescents can learn through meaningful projects, mentorship, practical work, ecological connection, and service to the wider community.

- **Phase 1 Capital Fund:** Supports Phase 1 renovations, including renovation of classrooms and shared learning spaces.
- **School Launch Donation:** Supports initial school setup, curriculum development, and equipment.
- **Scholarships:** Supports need-based assistance to students attending Canoe Valley School.
- **Endowment:** Supports expansion and long-term sustainability of the school's offerings, including long-term scholarship funds, and funds to support operations and capital improvements over time.
- **Planned Giving:** Supports the school's long-term financial health through thoughtful estate planning coordination.

Every gift, no matter how large or small, helps build a school rooted in this place and sustained by the community it serves.

OTHER WAYS TO SUPPORT US

Canoe Valley School is a community-supported project. It will grow through the care, imagination, labor, and generosity of families, neighbors, educators, mentors, and local partners who believe young people need meaningful places to learn, belong, and contribute.

There are many ways to help:

- **Volunteer on a school committee** to support planning in areas like curriculum, facilities, governance, fundraising, communications, or community partnerships.
- **Become a mentor** by sharing your craft, profession, land-based knowledge, artistic practice, technical skill, or life experience with students.
- **Offer in-kind labor or materials** to help renovate the building, improve outdoor learning spaces, support farm and garden infrastructure, or equip classrooms and studios.
- **Contribute professional services** such as legal, financial, design, construction, communications, grant-writing, nonprofit, or educational expertise.
- **Host or support community events** that introduce the school's vision, build relationships, and invite more people into the work.

Every contribution helps build a school rooted in this place and sustained by the community it serves.

Canoe Valley School is a 501(c)(3) non-profit educational institution.

To donate, visit:

https://canoevalley.org/donate/

or mail us at:

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1575 Manawa Trail Road
Decorah, IA 52101

To learn more, ask a question, or indicate interest in making a designated gift, please email us at:

info@canoevalley.org

CanoeValley.org